490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 2 OF 26

The God Who Is There

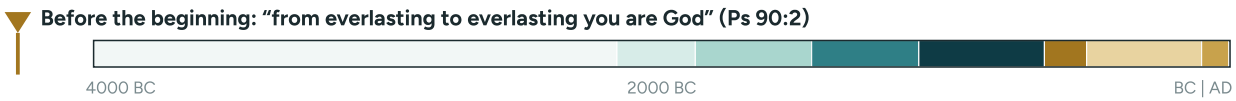
Genesis 1:1 · Exodus 3:14 · Psalm 19 · Isaiah 6



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 2



Introduction: Who Made God?

Sooner or later every child asks it. You tell them God made the trees and the stars and the puppy and them, and they think about it for a minute, and then they ask: “Then who made God?”

It is a better question than it sounds, and the Bible’s answer is the place every other answer starts. Nobody made God. Everything else had a beginning, and he is the one who gave it one. The first sentence of the Bible does not try to prove that he exists. It simply starts with him, the way a story starts with its storyteller: “In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth” (Gen. 1:1). Before the beginning, there was God.

Last week we stood back and looked at the whole story in four acts. This week we go back before Act One, before there was a world or a single star, and ask the first question of the story: who is the God who is there? The phrase comes from Francis Schaeffer, who used it as the title of a book in 1968 to describe the God the Bible actually presents. God is not an idea people came up with to explain things. He is a real, personal God who is really there, whether anyone believes in him or not.

This may be the most important lesson in the series. What you believe about God shapes everything else you believe: about yourself, about right and wrong, about suffering, about whether anyone is listening when you pray. John Calvin, a sixteenth-century pastor in Geneva, opened his great work on the Christian faith by saying that nearly all true wisdom comes down to two things, “the knowledge of God and of ourselves” (*Institutes* 1.1.1). We will spend the next lesson on ourselves. Today, God.

The Word: I AM



"He looked, and behold, the bush was burning, yet it was not consumed" (Ex. 3:2). A fire that needs nothing to keep it burning.

Around 1446 BC, a shepherd named Moses was keeping sheep in the desert near a mountain called Horeb. He saw a bush on fire, and it was not burning up. When he came closer, God spoke to him out of the flames and sent him to rescue Israel from slavery in Egypt. Moses asked the obvious question: when the people ask who sent me, what do I tell them?

> **Exodus 3:14–15** *"God said to Moses, 'I AM WHO I AM.' And he said, 'Say this to the people of Israel: "I AM has sent me to you."' God also said to Moses, 'Say this to the people of Israel: "The LORD, the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob, has sent me to you." This is my name forever, and thus I am to be remembered throughout all generations.'"*

יהוה *(YHWH, "the LORD")*

God's personal name, which he ties to the Hebrew verb "to be"

אֶהְיֶה (ʾehyeh)

"I AM"

From the verb *hayah*, "to be." It can also be read "I will be," as in God's promise two verses earlier, "I will be with you" (3:12). God names himself by his own being, and that being does not change.

→

יהוה (YHWH)

"the LORD"

In the very next verse God gives the name YHWH, built from the same verb. "I AM" is God speaking of himself; YHWH is how his people speak of him, probably meaning "He is." God calls it "my name forever" (3:15).

Payoff: This name appears nearly seven thousand times in the Old Testament, more than any other name for God. Over time Jewish readers stopped saying it aloud out of reverence and read "Lord" (*Adonai*) instead. Most English Bibles honor that by printing it in small capitals, so whenever you see "LORD" you are looking at God's personal name. Scholars think it was pronounced something like "Yahweh." The name tells you two things at once. First, God simply *is*. He depends on nothing, the way the fire in the bush needed nothing to keep it burning. Second, he is "the God of your fathers," the God who made promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob and keeps them. The God who needs no one has bound himself to his people by his word. Hold on to this name, because fifteen hundred years later a carpenter from Nazareth said to the religious leaders, "Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am," and they picked up stones to kill him. They knew exactly what he was claiming (John 8:58–59).

Moses "hid his face, for he was afraid to look at God" (Ex. 3:6). That is the right first response. The God who is there is a fire that burns without fuel. He is also the God who came down to that bush because he had "surely seen the affliction" of his people (3:7).

Part One: In the Beginning, God

> **Psalm 90:2** *"Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever you had formed the earth and the world, from everlasting to everlasting you are God."*

Psalm 90's heading calls it "a prayer of Moses," the same Moses who stood barefoot at the bush. Look at how he says it: from everlasting to everlasting, you are God. Look back past the first morning or forward past the last, and God is there, the same. He does not grow older. He does not move through time the way we do, waiting for tomorrow and losing yesterday. He made time, the way he made space, and he stands over all of it.

God has never needed anything. Before there was a world, there was nothing missing from him. The apostle Paul said it to a crowd of philosophers in Athens:

> **Acts 17:24–25** *"The God who made the world and everything in it, being Lord of heaven and earth, does not live in temples made by man, nor is he served by human hands, as though he needed anything, since he himself gives to all mankind life and breath and everything."*

Think about what that does to the way people usually picture God. Many of us assume, without ever saying it, that God is a bit like us: lonely, needy, or bored, so he made people to keep him company or to do things for him. The Bible says the opposite. You cannot give God anything he lacks, because he lacks nothing. Every breath you have ever taken came from him. Theologians call this God's *aseity*, from Latin words meaning "from himself." He has life in himself, and everything else has life from him.

At first that can feel cold, as if God does not need us and therefore does not care. It turns out to be the best news in the world, and you will see why in Part Five. A God who needs nothing from you is a God who can only give. He did not make you because he was empty. He made you because he was full.

Hebrews puts the starting point plainly: "whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him" (Heb. 11:6). He is, and he can be found.

Part Two: The God Who Shows Himself

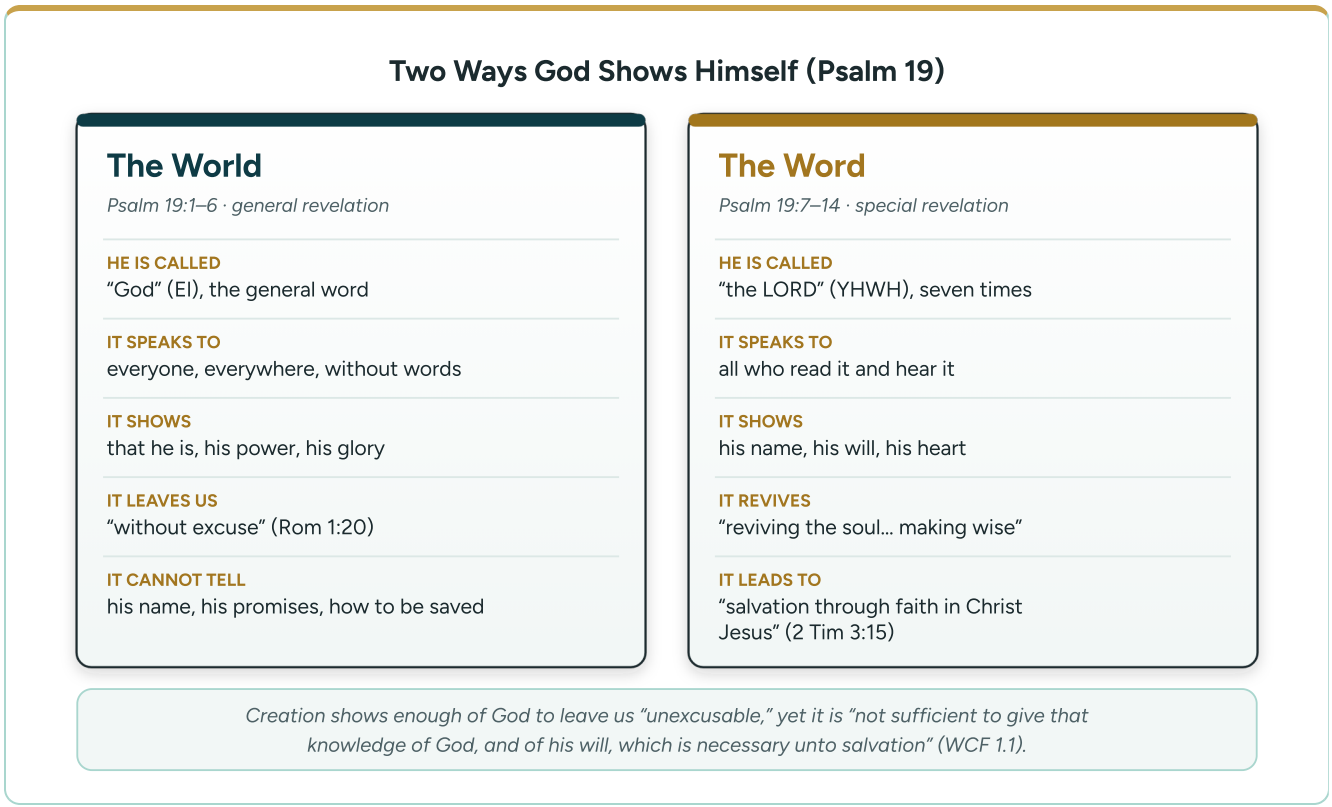
If God is this great, how could we ever know him? We could not, unless he showed himself. The Bible says he has, in two ways. David put both in one psalm. He was a shepherd before he was a king, and he must have spent a thousand nights on the hills outside Bethlehem looking up at the stars.

> **Psalm 19:1–3** *"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork. Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge. There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard."*

The sky preaches. It has no words, and yet every person on earth can hear it. Paul says the same thing in Romans: God's "invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made. So they are without excuse" (Rom. 1:20). Christians call this *general revelation*: what God shows of himself to everyone, everywhere, through the world he made and the conscience he put in us.

Then, halfway through the psalm, David changes subjects, and something changes with it:

> **Psalm 19:7–8** *"The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple; the precepts of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart; the commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes;"*



Look at the name. In the first half of the psalm, about the sky, God is called simply "God" (*El*, the general word). In the second half, about his Word, he is called "the LORD," the personal name from the burning bush, six times in three verses, and once more in the last line. The stars can tell you that God is great. Only his Word tells you his name. The sky shows his power. The Scriptures show his heart: his promises, his law, his plan to rescue.

The Westminster Confession says it carefully. Creation shows enough of God's "goodness, wisdom, and power" to leave people "unexcusable," yet it is "not sufficient to give that knowledge of God, and of his will, which is necessary unto salvation" (WCF 1.1). That is why God spoke, and why he had it written down. This second way is called *special revelation*: God speaking in words, and finally in his Son (Heb. 1:1–2). Today we have it in the Scriptures. Paul told Timothy the Scriptures "are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus" (2 Tim. 3:15). The stars cannot do that. They can bring you to your knees. Only the Word can tell you how to get up.

Also read: *Psalm 8; Isaiah 40:25–26; Romans 1:18–23; Acts 14:15–17*

Part Three: What Is God?

So what does the Word tell us God is like? For centuries Christian parents have taught their children the answer from the Westminster Shorter Catechism (a set of questions and answers written in the 1640s to teach the faith, still used in many Reformed churches, the churches that grew from the Reformation of

the 1500s; "WSC" from here on). Question 4 asks, "What is God?" The answer is one of the finest sentences ever written about him:

> **Westminster Shorter Catechism, Q. 4** *"God is a spirit, infinite, eternal, and unchangeable, in his being, wisdom, power, holiness, justice, goodness and truth."*

Read it slowly, because every word carries weight. God is **a spirit**: he has no body and no physical limits (John 4:24). He is **infinite**: there is no edge to him, nowhere he stops. He is **eternal**: no beginning, no end. He is **unchangeable**: "For I the LORD do not change" (Mal. 3:6), "with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change" (James 1:17). Then the sentence lists seven things that are true of him, and all three of those words apply to all seven. God's wisdom is infinite, eternal, and unchangeable. So is his power. So is his goodness. So is his justice. The seven words do not divide God into parts; each one describes the whole God. Nothing in God is small, temporary, or moody.

"What Is God?" (Westminster Shorter Catechism 4)

God is a spirit (John 4:24)

	infinite *no limits* Ps 139:7–8	**eternal** *no beginning or end* Ps 90:2	**unchangeable** *no variation* Mal 3:6
1 **Being** *Ex 3:14*	infinite being	eternal being	unchangeable being
2 **Wisdom** *Rom 11:33*	infinite wisdom	eternal wisdom	unchangeable wisdom
3 **Power** *Jer 32:17*	infinite power	eternal power	unchangeable power
4 **Holiness** *Isa 6:3*	infinite holiness	eternal holiness	unchangeable holiness
5 **Justice** *Deut 32:4*	infinite justice	eternal justice	unchangeable justice
6 **Goodness** *Ps 119:68*	infinite goodness	eternal goodness	unchangeable goodness
7 **Truth** *Num 23:19*	infinite truth	eternal truth	unchangeable truth

Every word across the top is true of every word down the side. Nothing in God is small, temporary, or moody.

That last part should be a deep comfort. People change. Your feelings about yourself change hour by hour. Even the people who love you most can grow tired or distant. God's goodness toward his people does not run low on a bad day. His truth does not shift when the culture shifts. "God is not man, that he should lie, or a son of man, that he should change his mind" (Num. 23:19).



"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!" (Isa. 6:3).

In Isaiah 6, one word about God is spoken with unusual force. Around 740 BC the prophet Isaiah was given a vision of the Lord on his throne in the temple, with angelic beings called seraphim ("burning ones") around him. "Each had six wings: with two he covered his face, and with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew. And one called to another and said: 'Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!'" (Isa. 6:2–3). Hebrew often repeats a word to make it emphatic, and saying it three times is rare. The seraphim say it of God, and in Revelation the creatures around the throne are still saying it (Rev. 4:8). God is holy beyond all measure.

"Holy" means set apart: so pure and so far above us that even the angels cover their faces. And Isaiah, a man who served God in Jerusalem, fell apart: "Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips; for my eyes have seen the King, the LORD of hosts!" (Isa. 6:5). When you see who God really is, you see who you really are.

But watch what happens next. One of the seraphim flew to Isaiah with a burning coal from the altar, the place of sacrifice, and touched his mouth: "Behold, this has touched your lips; your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for" (Isa. 6:6–7). To atone means to cover sin and make peace with God. The holy God made the unclean man clean, and he did it with fire from the altar. Keep that picture. It is a picture of the gospel before the gospel, and we will see it again.

When God described himself to Moses on the mountain, he put both sides together in one breath: "The LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness, keeping steadfast love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, but who will by no means clear the guilty" (Ex. 34:6–7). Merciful, and just. Forgiving, and he will not pretend sin is nothing. For most of the Old Testament, the question hangs in the air: how can God be both? The cross is the answer, and we are walking toward it.

Part Four: One God in Three Persons

Now we come to the deepest thing the Bible says about God, and the thing that most surprises people who did not grow up in church. The Bible insists, from start to finish, that there is only one God. Faithful Jews still recite it every morning and evening (see Deut. 6:7): "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one" (Deut. 6:4). And yet, as the story unfolds, we meet the Father, we meet the Son, and we meet the Holy Spirit, and each one is fully God.

The hints are there on the first page. "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.... And the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters. And God said, 'Let there be light'" (Gen. 1:1–3). God, his Spirit, and his spoken Word, all at work in creation. A few verses later God says, "Let us make man in our image" (1:26). Those early readers could not have explained it fully. The New Testament opens it up. John deliberately echoes Genesis: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.... All things were made through him" (John 1:1, 3). The Word was *with* God, so he is distinct from the Father. The Word *was* God, so he is not a lesser being. And John tells us who the Word is: "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (1:14). He is Jesus.



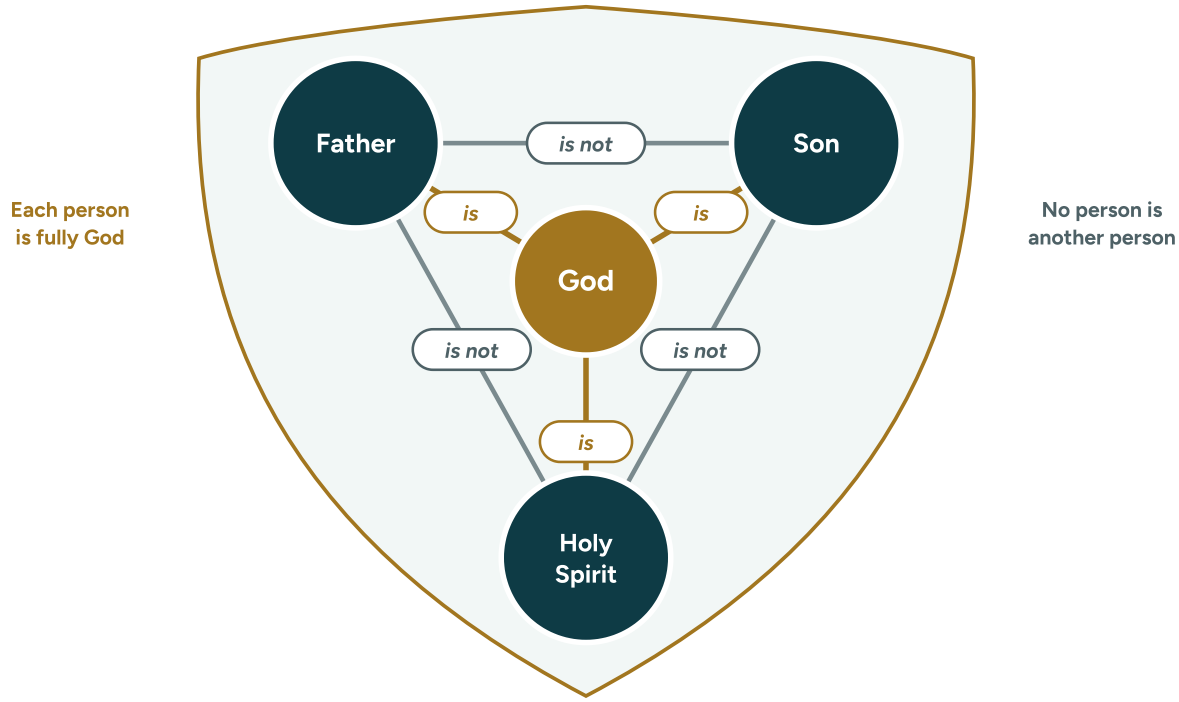
"The heavens were opened to him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming to rest on him; and behold, a voice from heaven said, 'This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased'" (Matt. 3:16–17).

At the Jordan River, around AD 27–29, all three appear at once. The Son stands in the water. The Spirit descends like a dove. The Father speaks from heaven. And when Jesus sent his followers out at the end of Matthew's Gospel, he told them to baptize "in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matt. 28:19). Mark that word: *name*, singular. One name, three persons.

A word about that word *person*. In the Trinity, a "person" does not mean a separate being, the way three people in a room are three beings. It means the Father, the Son, and the Spirit are truly distinct from one another in how they relate: the Father is the Father of the Son, the Son is the Son of the Father, and the Spirit comes from the Father and the Son (WCF 2.3). They share one being. When the Catechism below says "substance" or "Godhead," it means that one divine being. One What, three Whos.

The church gathered all of this into the word *Trinity* ("tri-unity"). The word is not in the Bible, but everything it describes is. The Shorter Catechism puts it simply: "There are three persons in the Godhead; the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost; and these three are one God, the same in substance, equal in power and glory" (WSC 6). "Holy Ghost" is the older English for the Holy Spirit.

The Shield of the Trinity



"These three are one God, the same in substance, equal in power and glory" (WSC 6).

Christians have drawn this diagram for about eight hundred years. It is called the Shield of the Trinity, and it keeps us from the two most common mistakes. Some people think God is one person who wears three masks, appearing sometimes as the Father, sometimes as the Son, sometimes as the Spirit. That cannot be right, because at the Jordan all three are present at the same moment, and elsewhere the Son prays to the Father (John 17:1) and promises to send the Spirit from the Father (John 15:26). Others think of the Father, Son, and Spirit as three gods, or three thirds of one god. That cannot be right either, because God is one, and each person is fully God. The shield holds both truths: each person *is* God, and no person *is* another.

Will you fully understand this? No. Neither do I, and neither did Augustine or Calvin. Most comparisons you will hear (water, ice, and steam; an egg with shell, white, and yolk) end up teaching one of the two mistakes. It is better to say what the Bible says and then bow. A God you could fully figure out would be a God about your size. The Trinity is exactly what you would expect if the God who is there is far greater than us and has truly told us about himself.

Also read: *John 14:16–17, 26; 2 Corinthians 13:14; Ephesians 1:3–14; Matthew 28:18–20*

Part Five: The God Who Needs Nothing and Loves Freely

The Trinity matters for your life, not only for your doctrine. The Bible says "God is love" (1 John 4:8). If God were a single, solitary person, we might wonder whether his love had to wait for a world to give it somewhere to go. God has never been alone, and his love has never been waiting. On the night before he died, Jesus prayed to his Father about the glory "that you have given me because you loved me before the foundation of the world" (John 17:24). Before there were stars, the Father loved the Son and the Son loved the Father, in the Holy Spirit, who is himself fully God. The Father did not need the Son the way a lonely man needs a friend. Father, Son, and Spirit are the one God, and this love is simply what God is, full and complete forever.

So go back to Part One. God does not need you. He was perfectly happy and full of love before you existed. That means he did not create the world to fill a hole in himself. He created it out of fullness, to share what he already had. God could have made nothing at all and lost nothing. He made the world because he freely willed to. The elders in Revelation sing, "Worthy are you, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they existed and were created" (Rev. 4:11). He made all things by his own free will, and he was glad to.

And that changes how you can come to him. You do not have to earn your way in by being useful. You cannot make him love you by giving him something he lacks. The only way to come to a God like this is with empty hands, the way Isaiah came, the way every one of us must come. Paul ends a long, hard chapter about God's plan by simply breaking into worship: "For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever. Amen" (Rom. 11:36).

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The God who fills heaven and earth needs no house: "Do I not fill heaven and earth? declares the LORD" (Jer. 23:24). So when this God later chooses to live in a tent among his people, it will be pure grace, never need.

THE LAMB The rescue was planned before there was anything to rescue. Peter says we were ransomed "with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot," and that Christ "was foreknown before the foundation of the world" (1 Pet. 1:19–20). Before the first star, the Lamb was already chosen.

The Turn: The God Who Has Made Himself Known

Moses hid his face at the bush. Isaiah cried "Woe is me" in the temple. Even the seraphim cover their faces. And John, after all of that, writes one of the most daring sentences in the Bible:

> **John 1:18** *"No one has ever seen God; God the only Son, who is at the Father's side, he has made him known."*

That sounds like it contradicts Isaiah, who said, "my eyes have seen the King." John answers it himself. Writing about Isaiah's vision, he says, "Isaiah said these things because he saw his glory and spoke of him" (John 12:41), and the "him" is Jesus. What Isaiah saw in the temple was the glory of the Son, the one who makes the Father known.

The word for "made him known" is the root of our word "exegesis," to lead out, to explain. Jesus is God explaining himself. If you want to know what the God who is there is like, you do not have to climb to heaven or decode the stars. Look at Jesus. Look at him touching lepers, welcoming children, weeping at a friend's grave, forgiving a sinful woman who wept at his feet (Luke 7:47–48). When Philip, one of the Twelve, asked Jesus to show them the Father, Jesus answered, "Whoever has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9).

And look at what Jesus came to do. Isaiah needed a coal from the altar to take away his guilt. Every one of us stands where Isaiah stood, with unclean lips and an unclean heart, before a God who is holy, holy, holy. Jesus came to be the sacrifice on that altar. The holy God met his own standards himself, in his Son, so that he could be both just and merciful at once. That is what you will watch unfold, lesson by lesson, all the way to the cross.

Through the prophet Jeremiah, God told his people what was worth boasting about. Not wisdom, not strength, not money, "but let him who boasts boast in this, that he understands and knows me, that I am the LORD who practices steadfast love, justice, and righteousness in the earth" (Jer. 9:24). And Jesus told us what eternal life is: "that they know you, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent" (John 17:3).

So this is the invitation of the whole Bible, and of this lesson. The God who is there can be known. He has spoken. He has come. He calls you to turn from your sin and trust his Son, and he promises that whoever comes to him will be received. If you already know him, then let this lesson make you smaller and him larger in your eyes, and let that be a relief. If you do not yet know him, you do not need to understand everything first. You need to come as Isaiah came, honest about your sin, and trust Jesus, the sacrifice God provided, to take your guilt away. He has promised, "whoever comes to me I will never cast out" (John 6:37).

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Look up.** Spend five minutes outside one night this week looking at the sky. Read Psalm 19:1–6 out loud while you do. Let the sky preach to you.

2. **Learn the Catechism answer.** Memorize WSC 4: "God is a spirit, infinite, eternal, and unchangeable, in his being, wisdom, power, holiness, justice, goodness and truth." It takes about a week of saying it once a day.

3. **Watch for LORD.** As you read your Bible, notice every time "LORD" appears in small capitals, and remember the bush. That is God's own name.

4. **Pray as a Christian.** Pray to the Father, through the Son, by the help of the Spirit (Eph. 2:18). Then close your prayers this week with the blessing Paul gave the Corinthians: "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all" (2 Cor. 13:14).

5. **Correct one picture.** Write down one way you have imagined God as smaller, needier, or moodier than he is. Then find one verse from this lesson that corrects it.

6. **Memorize Exodus 3:14.** "God said to Moses, 'I AM WHO I AM.'" Carry it into every hard day this week. He is.

Before Lesson 3: *Read Genesis 1–2 and Psalm 8. Lesson 3 asks what it means that God made us in his own image.*

For Discussion

1. How would you have answered a child who asked, "Who made God?" before this lesson? How would you answer now?
2. Read Acts 17:24–25. Why might it be good news, and not cold news, that God does not need anything from us?
3. Psalm 19 shows God speaking through the sky and through his Word. What can the stars tell you about God? What can they never tell you?
4. Walk through the seven words in WSC 4 (being, wisdom, power, holiness, justice, goodness, truth). Which one do you most need to remember is infinite, eternal, and unchangeable this week? Why?
5. Isaiah saw God's holiness and cried, "Woe is me!" Why do you think seeing God clearly made him see himself clearly? What did God do about it?
6. Using the Shield of the Trinity, explain in your own words why God is not one person in three masks, and not three gods.
7. Jesus said, "Whoever has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9). What is one thing about Jesus in the Gospels that shows you what God is like?

Sources & For Further Study

- Westminster Shorter Catechism (1647), Q. 4 and Q. 6. Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), 1.1; 2.1; 2.3.
- John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* 1.1.1 (Beveridge translation).
- On יהוה and אֶהְיֶה: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament*, s.v. הָיָה; Koehler and Baumgartner, *HALOT*, s.v. יהוה.
- Francis A. Schaeffer, *The God Who Is There* (1968).
- On the Shield of the Trinity (*Scutum Fidei*): a diagram of this kind appears in manuscripts of Peter of Poitiers (c. 1210), and in shield form in English manuscripts of the 1200s.
- For further reading: J. I. Packer, *Knowing God*; A. W. Tozer, *The Knowledge of the Holy*; R. C. Sproul, *The Holiness of God*; Michael Reeves, *Delighting in the Trinity*.



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